of the passengers ran out when it landed in Madurai. It was so insignificant compared to what Gupta was so delightfully going through.

Every time he manoeuvred through turbulence, I sat mesmerised as much by the forces of nature as by man's zeal to tame them more by respecting the elements than disregarding them. At times, science makes you philosophical. Flying a small aircraft through pitfalls in the air should take a lot of science, philosophy and guts. I had never been afraid of flying; and now my adventures with Gupta conditioned me to remain as calm as the pilot when the aircraft is tossed around by atmospheric pressure dips and uneven winds.

So, when TERLS director H G S Murthy, a man of practical jokes, tried to scare aerodynamics engineer Y Janardhana Rao and me on our way from Paris, I smirked. The flight was above the Alps when Murthy, sitting on an aisle seat suddenly craned his neck to look at the engine beyond Rao on the window seat.

'Did you hear that unusual sound?' Murthy said, apparently sensing Rao's fear of flying.

I knew what was coming, and sat still. Rao was a bit rattled and strained his ears.

'Yeah, it must be the pilot adjusting the flaps,' said Rao, more to reassure himself than anyone else.

'I don't think so,' Murthy continued with the prank. 'Sounds like something is wrong with that engine.'

Rao snapped, 'Murthy, now will you please keep silent?'

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Many academic programmes in Princeton worked thus: you enrol as a research scholar, you have to complete seven subjects for credit. This, plus a completed project work will make you eligible for your masters. Many took two—a few three—subjects in a semester of five months, I took four in a semester and three in the next, simultaneously working on the project to complete the requirements for the masters in ten-and-a-half months.